

The Hansard

A WEEKLY DIGEST OF THE PROCEEDINGS OF THE PARLIAMENT OF THE UNITED KINGDOM

Nigel Farage resigns his seat

The week’s biggest story was a resignation the official record has yet to catch up with. On Tuesday 7 July Nigel Farage announced that he would resign as the Member for Clacton and fight the by-election his departure will trigger — “the people versus the establishment,” as he cast it. A Member cannot simply quit: he must be appointed to a nominal Crown office, the

Chiltern Hundreds, and the seat falls vacant only when the Chancellor signs the warrant. Until then the record still lists him as Clacton’s sitting Member, and as this issue goes out, it does. He took the seat in 2024 with 21,225 votes and a majority of 8,405 on a 46 per cent share; whatever the by-election decides will be measured against those numbers. The move follows press

reports of undeclared support before that election, now before Parliament’s standards commissioner; Farage denies any wrongdoing. Around the announcement, the Commons had a heavier legislative week than the headlines suggested — a new state-threats law on the statute book, and a reckoning with foreign money in politics.

THE DIVISIONS, CLOSEST FIRST	
Taxation (Energy and Vehicles) Bill, New Clause 4	173–282
Opposition Day, Early Release of Prisoners	115–0
Taxation (Energy and Vehicles) Bill, New Clause 5	177–308
Taxation (Energy and Vehicles) Bill, New Clause 2	80–281
Employment Tribunals jurisdiction order	318–107
Employment Tribunal time-limit regulations	322–107
National Security Bill, Lords Amendment 1	394–85

THE WEEK IN BRIEF

Royal Assent for the State Threats Act, 8 July. The National Security (State Threats) Bill became law, giving the Home Secretary a designation power close to proscription for organisations acting for a foreign power. The Commons had agreed the Lords humanitarian activity defence two days earlier by 394 votes to 85.

Foreign Interference in UK Politics, 6 July. The democracy minister Samantha Dixon made a statement publishing the Government response to Philip Rycroft’s independent review. The Government accepted every recommendation and promised tighter rules on overseas and cryptoasset donations.

Rochdale grooming gang deportation, 6 July. A Home Office minister took an urgent question on Shabir Ahmed, released on licence on 2 July, who cannot be deported because he arrived before 1973. Alex Norris said all options were on the table, including emergency legislation.

Early release of prisoners, 7 July. A Conservative opposition day motion on the early release of prisoners was carried 115 votes to nil, the Government abstaining by the usual convention.

WRITTEN QUESTIONS, BY DEPARTMENT

Health	272
Defence	254
Transport	248
Home Office	151
Ministry of Justice	128
Environment	128
Treasury	122
Cabinet Office	121
17 others	654

THE MOST-ASKED SUBJECTS

20 Immigration · 19 Lord Mandelson · 15 Conversion Therapy · 14 Pregnancy: Thromboembolism · 13 Ministry of Defence: Artificial Intelligence · 13 Pre-school Education: Teachers · 12 Department for Transport: Artificial Intelligence · 12 Forests: Environment Protection · 11 Department for Business and Trade: Artificial Intelligence · 11 Revenue and Customs: Artificial Intelligence

THE FEATURE

The Mandelson file: twenty-four questions, one member

The most concentrated written question press of the week came from one member. Mike Wood, the Conservative for Kingswinford and South Staffordshire, tabled twenty-four questions on the appointment of Lord Mandelson as ambassador to Washington.

They probe the security vetting decision, the redaction and disclosure of the appointment papers, and the roles of senior officials. Several answers note material withheld at the request of the Metropolitan Police.

A SAMPLE OF THE WEEK’S QUESTIONS

Local Government Finance · Blake Stephenson, Conservative

What assessment she has made of the potential impact of her policies for fiscal devolution in relation to income tax on trends in the level of funding for local authorities.

THE ANSWER At her Mais Lecture, the Chancellor committed to work with mayors, businesses and other stakeholders to develop a fiscal devolution roadmap, to be published at the Budget, setting out plans to give regional leaders control over the allocation of a share of some national taxes. This work includes considering income tax alongside other taxes.

THE MOST ACTIVE

Ben Obese-Jecty asked more written questions than any other Member of Parliament this week with 81. Mrs Sharon Hodgson answered the most with 144.